

3.6.1.10 Converting Non-Numbers To Actual Values

If you often import data into Excel from various applications, including Access, you'll find that values are sometimes imported as text, which means you can't use them in calculations or with commands that require values. This is a common problem in Excel. The good news is the Excel can identify such cells and you can easily correct them. You can use this method:

- m Select any empty cell
- m Enter the value 1 into that cell
- m Choose **Edit > Copy**
- m Select all the cells that need to be converted
- m Choose **Edit > Paste Special**
- m In the 'Paste Special' dialog box, select the 'Multiply' option, then click 'OK'.

This operation multiplies each cell by 1, and in the process converts the cell's contents to a value.

As we mentioned, there are thousands of formulas and functions you can use in Excel, and the above are just indicative. For a complete listing of Excel's formulas and their syntax, refer to Excel's Help with the keywords 'Worksheet functions listed by category'.

3.7 Pivot Table Reports

3.7.1 Why Use Pivot Table Reports?

Let's suppose you've compiled a large list of data—for example, sales figures for every product your company makes. But now you're ready to distil some meaningful information from the data. For example, you might want to answer the following questions:

- m What is the total sales for each product by region?
- m Which products are selling best over time?
- m Who is your highest-performing salesperson?

For these and other questions, you can create a 'PivotTable' report—an interactive table that automatically extracts, organises,